FUTURES MATTER EDUCATION

Futures Matter - Northwood, 122 Emily Street, Highgate, Birmingham, B12 0XJ

English as an Additional Language Policy

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1.0 AIMS

Some of our pupils and families have English as an additional language (EAL). The range of home languages in our community continues to grow, and we see this diversity as a strength: it brings new cultural experiences and helps to break down barriers. We recognise that pupils and families with EAL can face extra challenges, and our pupils already have social, emotional and mental health needs and autism. We aim to meet those needs early and with care.

We believe that:

- all pupils are entitled to equal access to the curriculum and to the support set out in their EHC plan
- knowing and using more than one language is an asset, and supports learning, identity and wellbeing
- developing a pupil's home language has a positive effect on how they learn English and other languages
- strong links with parents and carers are fundamental to a pupil's learning and development
- we should find out about each pupil's needs as soon as possible, and involve pupils and families in the plan

The government describes a bilingual learner as a pupil who uses, or has access to, more than one language at home or at school. It does not mean that they are fully fluent in all of them.

2.0 LEGISLATION AND GUIDANCE

- The Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014, including the standards on the quality of education and on the spiritual, moral, social and cultural development of pupils
- Equality Act 2010, which protects pupils from discrimination because of race, which includes nationality and ethnic or national origin
- Children and Families Act 2014 and the SEND Code of Practice (2015). A child is not to be regarded as having a learning difficulty or disability only because the language spoken at home is different from the language they are taught in
- Our duty under the Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy and Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026 to communicate with children and families in a way that they understand

3.0 ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

Who	Responsibilities
The Proprietor and the School Governance Board	Make sure the school has enough resources to support EAL pupils, and receive a report on EAL provision at least once a year.

Who	Responsibilities
The Head Teacher	Has the special educational needs coordinator duties at the school. Is responsible for this policy, for assessing and recording each pupil's language needs, for liaison with placing authorities and external services, and for making sure EAL needs are included in each EHC plan review.
Teachers and support staff	Plan lessons that all pupils can understand, use the strategies in section 6, know each pupil's language profile, and record progress. Every teacher is a teacher of language.
Finance and Business Support Manager	Keeps the record of home languages and arranges translation and interpreting, with the Head Teacher.

This list is not exhaustive.

4.0 FINDING OUT ABOUT EACH PUPIL

Before a pupil joins us, and on admission, we ask parents and carers about their child's ethnicity, home language, first language and other languages, and religion, so that we can support the family. We also gather:

- the pupil's language background, and how well they use each language they know
- their previous education and any gaps or breaks in schooling, and the family's circumstances where the family is willing to share them
- the placing authority's information, including the language and communication needs in the EHC plan
- how the pupil understands, speaks, reads and writes English, assessed with our own tools and, where useful, a recognised scale for proficiency in English
- the views of the pupil and their family about what would help

An assessment takes place in the first weeks, in a calm and familiar setting, and is repeated each term. We keep the results with the pupil's records, which are confidential to the family and to the staff who need them.

5.0 EAL ALONGSIDE SEMH AND AUTISM

Working out whether a difficulty is a normal part of learning an additional language, or a sign of a separate communication need, is not easy. Many of our pupils have some form of communication difficulty whether or not they have EAL. We therefore:

- assess a pupil's understanding and use of language (receptive and expressive), taking their EAL status into account, and use the speech and language therapist or an educational psychologist where there is doubt
- look at how the pupil communicates in their home language as well as in English, with the family's help and an interpreter if needed
- do not assume that a pupil's behaviour is only about language, or only about SEMH or autism. Anxiety, trauma, a recent move and a new language can all show up as withdrawal, distress, or behaviour that challenges

- recognise that autism can make learning another language harder, and that some pupils may have experienced trauma, loss or migration
- make sure that behaviour sanctions and restrictive interventions are never applied because a pupil did not understand an instruction. Staff check that the pupil understood what was said

6.0 HOW WE SUPPORT PUPILS

The DfE has produced guidance on supporting pupils for whom English is an additional language, and the ideas in it match what we do in everyday planning and teaching. All pupils with EAL are taught within their own classes and curriculum, with the support below.

- use gesture, visuals, symbols, objects and real examples, and visual timetables
- model social conventions and teach the names of staff and key routines
- speak clearly and at a steady pace, check understanding, and give time to answer
- key word lists, picture dictionaries, bilingual dictionaries and translation tools, with writing frames and sentence starters
- pre-teach key vocabulary before a lesson and revisit it afterwards
- paired and small group work, and calm opportunities for speaking and listening, with a patient adult or peer
- differentiate lessons to each pupil's language ability, and give the same high expectations of thinking and learning
- let pupils use their home language to help them think and learn, and to show what they know
- teach English directly in small steps where needed, with extra individual or small group sessions
- use external services where needed, for example a speech and language therapist, educational psychologist or specialist EAL support
- where it helps a pupil, entry for an external qualification in their first language to build their confidence

The support for each pupil is set out in their pupil profile (Appendix 1) and in their EHC plan targets, and is reviewed each term.

7.0 HOME LANGUAGE AND IDENTITY

We place great value on each pupil developing as an individual according to their religious, cultural and personal beliefs, and we work with families to support this. The school community can learn about each other's languages and cultures through:

- cultural days, themed weeks and assemblies that reflect the languages and cultures of our community
- visits to places of worship and community places, risk assessed under the Educational Visits Policy
- displaying pupils' work in different languages and about different cultures
- making sure that books and resources show a range of ethnicities and are available in different languages

- working closely with families to understand how special needs are seen in their culture

Families may have come across old advice that a child with additional needs should not use the home language. Staff must reassure families that current guidance says that the best language model for a child is the language in which the family is most fluent.

8.0 WORKING WITH FAMILIES AND TRANSLATION

- We work to build strong links with all families, and make sure language is not a barrier to being part of the school. We invite parents to share their views, and tell them regularly about their child's progress.
- We make sure that important information, such as policies, letters, consent forms, EHC plan reviews and reports, can be understood by families. We provide it in the family's language or in an accessible format, or explain it with an interpreter.
- We arrange an interpreter for annual reviews, meetings about safeguarding or behaviour, medical meetings and parents' evenings when this is needed. A professional interpreter or a trusted translator is used wherever possible.
- Parents and carers are welcome to bring their own translator, whether a professional, a friend or a family member, to meetings.
- Pupils are never used as interpreters for their parents, especially for sensitive or safeguarding matters, and we do not use a family member as an interpreter when a safeguarding concern is being discussed with the family or when we need to hear a person's views independently.
- Through links with local communities, we keep a list of recommended local contacts who can translate or interpret. Staff who speak other languages may help with day to day conversations, but not with formal meetings.
- We use the Brasshouse Translation, Interpreting and Accessible Information Services: btis@birmingham.gov.uk

9.0 RECRUITMENT

We employ staff irrespective of their home language. We will check at interview that a candidate's English is suitable for the post, as the law requires. Staff are not required to say what languages they speak, but some staff may be able to speak to a pupil or family in their language, and be a positive role model for pupils who may feel self-conscious that English is not their first language.

10.0 MONITORING, FUNDING AND RESOURCES

- We monitor each pupil's progress in English and in the curriculum, through termly pupil progress reviews, discussion with staff, EHC plan reviews and the annual report.
- Records are kept by the Head Teacher and are confidential.
- We use a range of resources: visual supports, symbols, differentiated worksheets, key word lists, bilingual dictionaries and software. The Head Teacher reports to the Board on spending.

- We do not receive specific EAL funding. We meet the cost from the school budget, and raise with placing authorities any extra provision that a pupil needs, such as interpreting or specialist support.
- This policy is reviewed every year by the Head Teacher and approved by the School Governance Board.

11.0 LINKS WITH OTHER POLICIES

- SEND Policy and Accessibility Plan
- Admissions Policy
- Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy
- Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy
- Curriculum Policy
- Equality information

References: DfE, EAL guidance and resources; SEND Code of Practice (2015); The Key, EAL policy guidance.

12.0 APPENDICES

Appendix 1: EAL Pupil Profile

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PUPIL PROFILE (complete on admission and review each term)	
Pupil name, year group and date of admission:	
Home language(s) and other languages used, and who in the family speaks them:	
Languages the pupil reads and writes, and how well they use each language:	
Previous education, including any gaps, and the date of arrival in the UK if relevant:	
Information from the EHC plan about language and communication, and from any speech and language assessment:	
Proficiency in English: understanding, speaking, reading and writing (give the date and the tool used):	
How the pupil and family prefer to communicate, and whether an interpreter is needed (language and dialect):	
What helps this pupil to learn, and to feel calm and safe, including the use of the home language:	
Support put in place: strategies, extra sessions, resources and outside services:	
Targets for the term, and who is responsible:	
Review date, progress and next steps (record the views of the pupil and family):	